

F. Preparation for the Repudiation of Versailles 1933-1935

After the seizure of power, Hitler's first concern was an immediate strengthening of the German armed forces in all respects. This was a necessary preliminary to repudiation of the Versailles Treaty and reoccupation of the Rhineland, both of which had to be accomplished before more ambitious steps could be taken. Equipment of all types was needed, and needed quickly. At this point the value of the secret development work which Krupp's had been doing proved itself. Large-scale production of tanks, artillery and, in due course, submarines, of the most advanced and modern type, could be started immediately.

1. Artillery.

Grusonwerk received orders immediately for the production of anti-aircraft guns and other war material (Exh. 291, NIK-8188, Bk. 8, p. 129). A Krupp document states on this point, "Immediately after the seizure of power the Navy, as the most powerful part of the Wehrmacht, began, with us, to equip and expand our factory installations for the production of war materials. In view of our location in the heart of the Reich, favorable from a military point of view, the production of especially important Wehrmacht equipment was entrusted to us from the very outset and plant facilities for a much greater capacity than would be required for peace time needs was set up in case of war" (Exh. 266, NIK-11178, Bk. 8, p. 27).

The parent plant at Essen also felt the effects of the change in regimes. On August 1, 1933 it received an order for six units of the 21 cm mortar, to be finished April 30, 1934 and on 1 September 1933 for six units of the 15 cm gun under the camouflage name 17,5 cm V gun, to be finished by January 31, 1934 (Exh. 269, NIK-11821, Bk. 8, p. 42; Exh. 309, D-215, Bk. 8, p. 171).